Roadmap to the Haemonian Federation

A Consent-Based Plan for Balkan Reunification

Prepared as a speculative political-design exercise

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Abstract

This document sketches a long-horizon roadmap for a voluntary union of the Western and Central Balkan states, designed to be as durable as Yugoslavia was at its strongest (roughly 1950–1980) while avoiding the structural flaws that caused its collapse. It proposes a name, a power-sharing model, a phased timeline, a schematic border map and a flag. One deliberate departure from the brief: rather than giving any single country "predominant control", the design spreads leadership by *function*, because dominance by one nation is historically what destabilised both Yugoslavia and its predecessors.

Contents

1 Guiding Principles **3**

2 Lessons from Yugoslavia **3**

3 Name, Membership and Symbols **3**

3.1 Proposed Name . . . 3

3.2 Membership . . . 3

3.3 Capital and Institutional Seats . . . 4

3.4 Flag . . . 4

4 Governance Model: Distributed Leadership **4**

4.1 Why Not Predominant Control? . . . 4

4.2 Functional Leadership . . . 5

4.3 Institutions . . . 5

5 Border Map (Schematic) **5**

5.1 Border Policy . . . 6

6 Roadmap **6**

6.1 Phase 0: Foundations (2027–2030) . . . 6

6.2 Phase 1: Economic Area (2030–2036) . . . 7

6.3 Phase 2: Confederal Treaty (2036–2042) . . . 7

6.4 Phase 3: Federal Constitution (2042–2048) 7
6.5 Phase 4: Consolidation (2048–2060) 8

7 Building Strength Comparable to Yugoslavia **8**

8 Key Risks and Mitigations **8**

9 Honest Assessment **9**

1 Guiding Principles

1. **Consent, not coercion.** Every step requires parliamentary ratification and, for sovereignty transfers, a referendum with a qualified majority. A union imposed by force or pressure would reproduce the 1990s.
2. **No dominant nation.** Weighted institutions with caps, rotating offices and double-majority rules on vital interests.
3. **Economy first, symbols last.** Integration proceeds from trade and infrastructure to defence and citizenship, not the reverse.
4. **Compatibility with the EU and NATO.** Several prospective members already belong to both; the Union must be designed to join the EU as a bloc or to federate within it, never in opposition to it.
5. **Strong rule of law and minority guarantees** entrenched above ordinary legislation.

2 Lessons from Yugoslavia

What worked	What failed	Design response
Non-aligned diplomacy gave leverage between blocs	Over-reliance on one charismatic leader (Tito)	Collective, rotating presidency
Self-managed industry, strong export base	Debt crises and uneven regional development	Cohesion fund, central bank independence
Federal army as shared institution	Army became politicised; republics armed separately	Civilian-controlled joint force with mixed command
"Brotherhood and unity" brought real social mixing	Unity was enforced from above; nationalism suppressed rather than addressed	Open minority rights, truth commissions, free media
Republican constitutional autonomy (1974)	Veto structure paralysed the centre	Qualified majorities, deadlock-breaking court

3 Name, Membership and Symbols

3.1 Proposed Name

The Haemonian Federation (*Haemonska Federacija*; short form: *Haemonia*). The name derives from *Haemus*, the classical name of the Balkan range, and so avoids favouring any one nation's historical claims. Names such as "Illyria" or "South Slavia" were rejected because they exclude or privilege specific ethnic groups.

3.2 Membership

Founding core (9 units): Slovenia, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Serbia, Montenegro, Kosovo, North Macedonia, Albania, Bulgaria.

Associate track (optional): Greece and Romania, as members of a customs and defence-cooperation area. Both are long-standing EU/NATO members with strong independent interests, so full membership is unlikely and is not assumed.

The estimated combined population is about 28 million.

3.3 Capital and Institutional Seats

No single capital concentrates power. Seats are distributed:

Institution	Seat
Federal Parliament (ceremonial capital)	Sarajevo
Federal Court	Podgorica
Central Bank	Zagreb
Defence and Civil Protection Agency	Niš
Energy and Infrastructure Authority	Sofia
Cohesion and Development Fund	Skopje
Maritime and Ports Authority	Durrës
Technology and Research Agency	Ljubljana
Reconciliation and Minority Rights Commission	Pristina

3.4 Flag

Three horizontal bands—sea blue (Adriatic, Aegean and Black Sea), white (mountain snow and neutrality), forest green (land)—with a gold nine-pointed star, one point for each founding unit.



Flag of the Haemonian Federation (proportion 2:1)

4 Governance Model: Distributed Leadership

4.1 Why Not Predominant Control?

Assigning control to one or two countries (most obviously the largest by population) would signal to every other member that the Union is a vehicle for that country's interests. This is exactly the dynamic that unravelled the interwar Kingdom of Yugoslavia and then the socialist federation. A durable union therefore needs *functional leadership*: each member leads where it has real comparative strength, and no member leads everywhere.

4.2 Functional Leadership

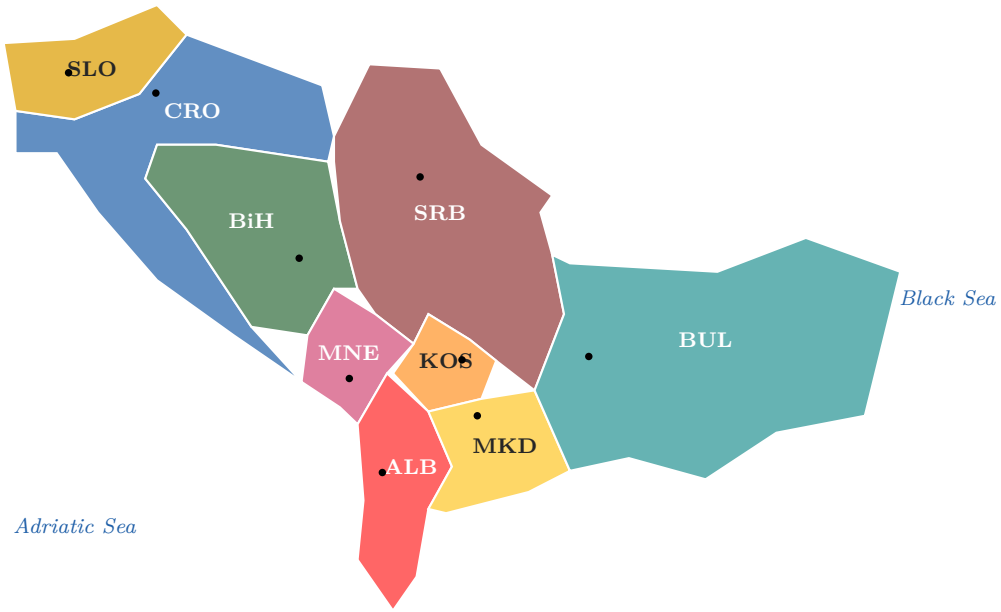
Member	Lead domain	Rationale
Slovenia	Finance, advanced manufacturing, research	Highest income per head, EU/eurozone experience
Croatia	Maritime economy, tourism, shipbuilding	Longest Adriatic coastline
Serbia	Logistics hub, defence industry, agriculture	Central location, Danube and rail corridors, large domestic market
Bulgaria	Energy, Black Sea ports, IT services	Nuclear and energy infrastructure, eastern gateway
Albania	Adriatic–Ionian ports, renewable energy	Hydropower, coastline
Bosnia and Herzegovina	Constitutional design, mining, hydropower	Experience with consociational systems
North Macedonia	Cohesion fund administration, transit	Vardar corridor connecting north and south
Montenegro	Federal judiciary, tourism	Small-state neutrality suits an arbiter role
Kosovo	Minority-rights commission, young workforce	Youngest population in Europe

4.3 Institutions

- **Presidency:** a nine-member Council, one member per unit, with the chair rotating every 12 months in a fixed rotation.
- **Chamber of Units (upper):** 6 seats per unit (54 total). Legislation affecting culture, language, religion or borders requires a two-thirds majority including at least two-thirds of the units concerned (double-majority rule).
- **Chamber of Citizens (lower):** proportional representation, with no single unit allowed more than 18% of seats, to prevent demographic dominance.
- **Federal Court:** nine judges, nominated by the units, with a mandate to resolve deadlocks within 90 days.
- **Federal share of revenue:** capped at 20% of GDP; most taxation stays at the unit level.
- **Official languages:** all recognised national languages, plus English as the working language of federal institutions.
- **Exit clause:** a clearly defined, difficult-but-possible withdrawal procedure. Counter-intuitively, a legal exit route reduces the risk of unilateral secession.

5 Border Map (Schematic)

The map below is a *stylised schematic*, not a survey. It assumes the internal borders of the founding units remain as they are today; the Federation creates no new borders and redraws none. Positions are approximate.



Schematic territory of the Haemonian Federation (nine founding units). Dots mark approximate capital cities. Not to scale.

5.1 Border Policy

- No existing international border is moved; the Union only removes internal border controls (Schengen-style).
- Federal and unit constitutions guarantee territorial integrity of each unit within its current borders.
- Border disputes (for example, certain maritime boundaries) go to the Federal Court or binding international arbitration before Phase 3.

6 Roadmap

Phase	Period	Core goal
0. Foundations	2027–2030	Reconciliation, legal harmonisation, public mandate
1. Economic area	2030–2036	Customs union, common market, shared infrastructure
2. Confederal treaty	2036–2042	Joint institutions, common currency track, joint security cooperation
3. Federal constitution	2042–2048	Referenda, constitutional convention, federal institutions
4. Consolidation	2048–2060	Full integration, fiscal union, EU alignment

6.1 Phase 0: Foundations (2027–2030)

1. Establish a **Balkan Reconciliation Commission** with independent historians from all nine units; produce a joint, publicly funded account of the 1990s conflicts and earlier wars.
2. Resolve outstanding issues that would block integration: missing persons, war-crimes prosecutions, property restitution, refugee return, and recognition questions (notably Kosovo's status).

3. Harmonise commercial, customs and professional-qualification law building on CEFTA and the Open Balkan initiative.

4. Launch a **citizens' assembly** in each country (randomly selected, 200 members) to deliberate on whether and how to proceed; publish results.

5. Commission baseline polling. *Gate:* proceed only if every unit shows majority support for entering Phase 1.

6.2 Phase 1: Economic Area (2030–2036)

1. Full customs union and removal of non-tariff barriers; single digital market; mutual recognition of diplomas.

2. **Roaming and payment union**: eliminate cross-border mobile and banking fees.

3. Build the **Haemonian Corridor**: high-speed rail linking Ljubljana–Zagreb–Belgrade–Niš–Skopje–Thessaloniki/Sofia, plus Adriatic–Ionian motorway and Danube port upgrades.

4. Integrate electricity grids and create a regional energy market with a shared strategic reserve.

5. Create the Cohesion Fund (1% of combined GDP, rising to 2%), directed toward the poorest regions.

6. *Gate:* measurable convergence—intra-area trade up by at least 50%, and no unit's unemployment gap widening.

6.3 Phase 2: Confederal Treaty (2036–2042)

1. Sign the **Treaty of Sarajevo**, creating the Presidency Council, a consultative parliament and the Federal Court on a provisional basis.

2. Establish a shared currency path: peg to the euro, then adopt either the euro directly or a common currency with a joint central bank.

3. Create a joint civil-protection and defence-planning body; hold combined exercises; consolidate defence procurement while keeping national forces.

4. Common foreign-policy coordination with a joint representation at international institutions where members agree.

5. Harmonise social-security portability and pensions.

6. *Gate:* each national parliament ratifies by a two-thirds vote.

6.4 Phase 3: Federal Constitution (2042–2048)

1. Elect a **Constitutional Convention** (equal delegations per unit, plus citizen delegates and minority representatives).

2. Draft the federal constitution embedding the governance model in Section 4, plus a bill of rights enforceable by the Federal Court.

3. **Referenda in every unit.** Adoption requires approval by a majority of voters in *each* unit and in every internal region with constitutionally recognised autonomy. A unit that votes no does not join; the others may proceed, and the door stays open.

4. Transfer defined competences: foreign trade, monetary policy, external border control, joint defence command.
5. Create federal citizenship in parallel with national citizenship.

6.5 Phase 4: Consolidation (2048–2060)

1. Unified armed forces under civilian command with mixed-language, mixed-origin units.
2. Fiscal union: federal budget, joint debt instrument, stabilisation mechanism for regional shocks.
3. Coordinate EU relations: either accession of the Federation as an integrated bloc where the EU allows, or associated status with mutual market access for non-EU members.
4. Review the constitution after 12 years with a built-in revision mechanism.

7 Building Strength Comparable to Yugoslavia

Dimension	Strategy
Economy	Common market of ∼28 million, a diversified export base (machinery, automotive components, agri-food, IT, renewables); target GDP-per-capita convergence to 75% of the EU average by 2050.
Defence	Combined defence procurement and a joint rapid-reaction force; membership of NATO or neutrality to be decided by referendum, not assumed.
Energy	Shared hydropower, solar and nuclear capacity; interconnectors with Italy, Hungary, Romania and Turkey.
Infrastructure	The Haemonian Corridor, port consolidation and Danube navigation upgrades.
Human capital	Joint university network, mutual recognition of qualifications, and a programme to reverse emigration.
Diplomacy	Balanced relationships with the EU, the United States, Turkey, Russia and China, avoiding exclusive dependence on any one.
Social cohesion	Shared media fund, school-exchange programme, and a reconciliation curriculum.

8 Key Risks and Mitigations

Risk	Why it matters	Mitigation
Unresolved recognition of Kosovo	Several prospective members do not recognise it	Phase 0 gate; status-neutral formulas used by other unions
Bosnia's internal structure	Entities and cantons have their own vetoes	Entrench the existing arrangement and avoid reopening it
Historical grievances	Memory of the wars remains politically potent	Reconciliation Commission, trials, memorials
Great-power interference	External actors can exploit divisions	Transparency rules for foreign funding and media

Risk	Why it matters	Mitigation
EU/NATO obligations	Slovenia, Croatia, Bulgaria and Albania hold existing commitments	Federation designed to be EU-compatible; no step contradicts treaty law
Demographic imbalance	Larger units could dominate	Seat caps, double-majority rules
Public opposition	Union cannot succeed without popular support	Referendum gates and a no-penalty exit for any member that declines
Economic divergence	Poorer regions lag, breeding resentment	Cohesion Fund and infrastructure-first approach

9 Honest Assessment

This roadmap is a design exercise, not a forecast. At present there is no broad popular movement in these countries for political union; three of the nine founding members belong to the EU and treat that as their main strategic anchor, and recognition and historical disputes remain unresolved. The most realistic near-term path is the economic-area track of Phase 1, which parallels existing regional cooperation and EU accession. Everything beyond that depends on freely expressed public consent, and any version of this plan that bypasses that consent should be considered a failure of the plan rather than a shortcut.